

Blood and Coal Dust:
The Battle of Blair Mountain

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One million. That is approximately the number of rounds that were fired in late August to early September 1921 in the hills and hollows of southern West Virginia, in a confrontation years in the making between determined coal miners and a coalition of law enforcement and private detectives acting on the behest of mining magnates. In what became known as the Battle of Blair Mountain, named so after the peak where the bulk of the fighting occurred, organized labour engaged in the largest armed uprising since the American Civil War. This paper will explore the series of events that unfolded and show how the appalling conditions the coal miners of West Virginia faced combined with the wrongdoings of mining company owners and their cronies made armed conflict possible; it will further argue that this insurrection was in line with American revolutionary ideals.

It is best to begin by exploring the motivations behind the drastic course of action that the coal miners had opted to take. The rise of “Big Coal” originated in the need to facilitate American expansion and industrial growth.¹ But, one may ask, if coal was so important for the nation, would it not be the case that the workers and communities at the epicentre of extracting such a valuable resource should be rewarded handsomely for their contributions? As it turns out, this was not quite the case. America’s four largest coal companies controlled less than six percent of the coal market.² It was not that coal wasn’t a sought-after commodity. Rather, there was a substantial supply available across the United States, with mines present throughout the numerous coal-consuming regions of America with the exception of New England.³ The mines of southern West Virginia simply could not compete at an advantage with other producers due to their distance from the Atlantic Seaboard, rivers, and lakes where major markets were situated.⁴

¹ Lon Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21* (University of Pittsburgh Press, 1990), ix.

² Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, x.

³ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, x.

⁴ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, x.

The inevitable outcome of this was the reduction of wages for the coal miners of West Virginia, given that the mining company executives had no intention of taking the financial hit themselves.⁵ Nevertheless, there were times where the coal mines experienced times of great prosperity, in the form of economic booms. World War I represented such an instance. At peak of coal extraction during this economic boom in 1918, 579 million tons were produced, with 90 million tons coming from West Virginia alone.⁶ But by 1921 European demand had dwindled, with the domestic market failing to make use of all the excess coal production that had been ramped up by this stage. To make matters worse, an economic downturn in 1920 and 1921 had further exacerbated the situation.⁷

It was in this context that miners, labour unions, and coal executives headed down the path towards escalation. The First World War had provided high hours and improved wages for coal miners, a state of affairs that had kept at bay simmering tensions in the coal fields of West Virginia. Violence was not alien to this region; the Cabin Creek-Paint Creek Mine War of 1912-1913 was one such episode of bloodshed in neighboring Kanawha County.⁸ In that confrontation, thousands of miners had revolted in demand of higher wages and recognition of their unionization.⁹ Across West Virginia, appalling working and living conditions, compared by labour leader Samuel Gompers as being akin to those in Tsarist Russia, had brought about profound discontent against the coal operators. Further reminiscent of life under serfdom was the dictatorial control the mining companies exerted over “company towns”, with things like roads, land development, schooling, business dealings, and law enforcement all operating under the

⁵ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, x-xi.

⁶ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, xii-xiii.

⁷ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, xiii.

⁸ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, xii.

⁹ Robert Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America’s Largest Labor Uprising* (Basic Books, 2006), 11.

approval and behest of these private enterprises.¹⁰ In fact, the mining companies went as far as to pay their employees in “scrip” instead of U.S currency. These were vouchers that could only be redeemed at company-owned stores, which allowed the mining companies to keep all of their profits and gouge their employees with price increases at these stores.¹¹ So it is understandable that, with the Great War over, union leaders were keen to maintain the victories the coal miners had achieved for themselves as a result of the economic boom from the war and expand unionization across West Virginia. Chief among these unions was the United Mine Workers of America, or the UMWA. Likewise, coal executives were determined to claw back those very same benefits for their employees and to prevent such an outcome from come to fruition.¹² Several tools were employed against unionization to this end. So-called “yellow dog” contracts were utilized to prevent miners from joining unions; being in breach of these contracts not only meant facing termination, but given the fact that the coal companies provided housing for the miners, eviction from their homes.¹³ These evictions, and other such retaliations the mining companies undertook against unionized miners were carried out primarily via Baldwin-Felts Detective Agency.¹⁴

On May 19, 1920, a dozen or so private detectives from this very agency arrived in Matewan, Mingo County, West Virginia to carry out more evictions of miners at the behest of their employers.¹⁵ However, on this day they would face formidable resistance. Unlike in much of southern West Virginia, local leaders in Mingo County were not only sympathetic to the plight of coal miners, but had fostered an environment where unionization could occur, to the point that

¹⁰ David Alan Corbin, *Gun Thugs, Rednecks, and Radicals: A Documentary History of the West Virginia Mine Wars* (PM Press, 2011), 18-20.

¹¹ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 22.

¹² Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, xii.

¹³ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 15.

¹⁴ Corbin, *Gun Thugs, Rednecks, and Radicals: A Documentary History of the West Virginia Mine Wars*, 21-22.

¹⁵ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 9-10, 15-17.

by May 1920 roughly 3,000 of 4,000 miners in the County were claimed to be unionized. One such friend of the unions was Matewan mayor Cabell Testerman, who had appointed Sid Hatfield to serve as the town's police chief. Hatfield was a former coal miner himself, having experienced the same challenging and unsafe work conditions in the subterranean depths. He had developed a fierce reputation, in particular for his deadly marksmanship.¹⁶ This alongside the ghastly reputation Baldwin-Felts agents earned themselves through their Agency's reputation for brutality, notably including an incident where agents in two armored cars had opened fire with machine guns on a tent colony of striking miners in Colorado, explained the need for thirteen men to carry out the series of evictions they had planned out on that day.¹⁷ Soon after they began throwing miners and their families out of their homes on the outskirts of town, they were interrupted by Testerman and Hatfield, who demanded a written court order to prove the legality of the evictions. With the Baldwin-Felts agents being unable to produce such a document, Testerman went back into town to consult with the county prosecutor who advised him that the evictions were illegal and that warrants should be put out for the agents' arrest.¹⁸ The mayor also deputized a dozen men on the spot who had been chosen by a UMWA loyalist to serve as armed backup for Hatfield when the time came to carry out the arrests. Just as the Baldwin-Felts agents were approaching the train station to take them out of town they were once again confronted by Hatfield who informed them that they were under arrest, with their arrest warrants arriving on the next train into town.¹⁹ Albert Felts, the brother of one of the founders of the Baldwin-Felts Detective Agency, was in charge of the agents on that day, and he refused to be taken into custody; instead he chose to reach for his gun. Most accounts agree that Felts drew upon Testerman and fatally wounded him, and Hatfield would testify as such in a later United States

¹⁶ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 13-14.

¹⁷ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 16-17.

¹⁸ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 17.

¹⁹ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 17.

Senate hearing. The ensuing firefight would last some twenty minutes, see nearly one hundred rounds fired by men on both sides, and see two of Hatfield's men, Cabell Testerman, and seven Baldwin-Felts agents perish.²⁰

Retribution would be forthcoming for Hatfield. Having been charged with attacking non-unionized miners in McDowell County, a jurisdiction known for being anti-union,²¹ he was ordered to appear at trial at McDowell County Courthouse located in the county seat of Welch.²² Hatfield and his friends recognized the potential for this being a trap being set for him.²³ Nevertheless, on the morning of August 1, 1921, Hatfield alongside his wife Jessie, the widow of Cabell Testerman now Hatfield's wife, Ed Chambers who intended to testify on Hatfield's behalf, and his wife Sallie traveled to Welch. Chambers and Hatfield were unarmed as they ascended up the steps to the courthouse when they were both ambushed and shot dead in front of their wives by vengeful Baldwin-Felts agents. To cover their tracks, the Baldwin-Felts agents planted guns on both deceased men; a tactic that would prove to be successful given the later acquittal of the three men that had fired the fatal shots on the grounds of self-defense by what was likely a sympathetic McDowell County jury.²⁴

The killings at the courthouse served as the catalyst for the bloodbath that was to follow. Stirring oratory was delivered at the funeral for the two fallen men by the union-aligned political candidate Sam Montgomery, who demanded an end to the tyranny of the private detective

²⁰ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 9, 17-18; *West Virginia Coal Fields: Hearings Before the Committee on Education and Labor, United States Senate, 67th Congress, 1st Session, Pursuant to S. Res. 80, Directing the Committee on Education and Labor to Investigate the Recent Acts of Violence in the Coal Fields of West Virginia and Adjacent Territory and the Causes which Led to the Conditions which Now Exist in Said Territory* (1921), 206-207, 210.

²¹ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 36.

²² Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920-21*, 66.

²³ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920-21*, 66-67.

²⁴ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920-21*, 68-70; Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 82-83.

agencies. He railed against the “Sleek, dignified churchgoing gentlemen, who would rather pay fabulous sums to their hired gunmen, to kill and slay men for joining a union than to pay like or less amounts to the men who delve into the subterranean depths of the earth and produce their wealth for them”. There was widespread anger among miners of West Virginia, not only for Hatfield’s assassination and the fact that his killers had escaped justice, but also because of the ongoing injustices that unionized miners were facing at that very moment.²⁵ Adding insult to injury, West Virginia governor Ephraim Morgan denied a list of demands presented to him by several union and labour leaders, including the famous labour organizer Mother Jones. Thus, furious miners began to arm themselves and prepare for a rebellion on scale unlike anything America had seen in over half a century.²⁶ Soon, hundreds of armed miners began a march towards Mingo County with the intent of freeing union organizers and bringing about an end to the excesses and despotism of coal company backed agents and deputies. To get there, they would have to cross Logan County and confront its coal company friendly sheriff Don Chafin. Many of the firearms they wielded were those they had used during the Great War, with some comparing their circumstances to those in the Argonne.²⁷ Sheriff Chafin was determined to stymie miners’ efforts to reach Logan County; to this end he constructed trenches, mobilized thousands of anti-union defenders, erected machine gun posts, and even commandeered biplanes to use against the advancing miner army. Any hostile force approaching Logan County would have to get through the Blair Mountain Gap, a pass situated between the two peaks that comprised Blair Mountain.²⁸ Labour leaders of course wanted to prevent bloodshed. After they had informed the rebelling miners that U.S military had demanded that the march on Logan and

²⁵ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America’s Largest Labor Uprising*, 84.

²⁶ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, 75.

²⁷ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, 76–77; Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America’s Largest Labor Uprising*, 86.

²⁸ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America’s Largest Labor Uprising*, 86, 89.

Mingo Counties cease, most initially complied.²⁹ However, on August 27, state police tasked with reinforcing Chafin's defences at Blair Mountain opted to move against armed miners in the union-aligned Spruce Fork Valley resulting in a firefight with multiple fatalities and prisoners being taken by both sides. The state police were eventually overwhelmed and forced to retreat.³⁰

When reports came in to the miners about women and children being killed alongside their fellow union miners, the armed march immediately resumed and undertook an even greater sense of urgency. Mules, cars, trains, and all other available means of transportation were commandeered to propel the armed miners towards Logan County, with the insurrectionists now numbering in the thousands.³¹ At last, on August 31, 1921, armed coal miners and sheriff Chafin's defenders met at a 16-kilometer stretch of front line at the Blair Mountain pass. With the numbers of combatants on both believed to be anywhere from 10-20,000, the battle began.³² Despite many of the miners being combat veterans, the fact that the defenders held the high ground made their task quite formidable. Chafin's men were manning machine gun nests and rifle posts, and from their advantageous position strafed the miners with thousands of bullets every time they made an attempt to capture their positions.³³ Nevertheless the miners persisted, and by September 1 they were getting dangerously close to breaching the defences and entering Logan County. Chafin, terrified of the prospect of having his forces be overrun, resorted to having his biplanes drop homemade bombs and poison gas cylinders on the advancing rebels; fortunately for the miners the dropped ordnance missed their targets.³⁴ Unexploded bombs would

²⁹ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 90-92.

³⁰ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920-21*, 102-105, 109-110; Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 95.

³¹ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920-21*, 106-109, 111.

³² Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920-21*, 119-120.

³³ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 99.

³⁴ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 99-100.

later be showcased by the miners as evidence of the brutality they had faced.³⁵ One such bomb would later be used as evidence to acquit Bill Blizzard, one of the main leaders of the armed march, of treason.³⁶

Ultimately, it would take long-awaited federal intervention to end the carnage. U.S Air Force aircraft flew over the battlefield, indicating the imminent arrival of federal troops. Ironically, both sides believed that the troops would be on their side.³⁷ For the miners, it signaled the end of their will to fight. They were willing to engage in warfare against the coal mine operators and their cronies, but they would not wage hostilities against the United States itself. As such, they duly surrendered to arriving U.S forces.³⁸ In the aftermath, it was estimated that several dozen on both sides had perished during the battle at Blair Mountain. Given, the amount of forces on both sides, this was a much better outcome than what was initially feared;³⁹ this is especially so considering that roughly one million rounds were fired during the confrontation.⁴⁰ Taking the motivations and plight of the rebels into account, multiple sympathetic juries refused to convict numerous miners and organizers brought to trial on charges of treason, save for a minor participant in the rebellion by the name of Walter Allen.⁴¹

That the miners had chosen to carry out armed insurrection was something that had been encouraged by the philosophical framework under which the American Revolution had been fought. Among the most influential ideologues in the formation of the American Republic was

³⁵ "A Bomb Dropped on Miners" Bill Blizzard, UMWA, and the Battle of Blair Mountain.

<https://omekas.lib.wvu.edu/home/s/umwa-battle-of-blair-mountain/item/1126>.

³⁶ "Miners Put On Trial" Bill Blizzard, UMWA, and the Battle of Blair Mountain.

<https://omekas.lib.wvu.edu/home/s/umwa-battle-of-blair-mountain/page/Minersontrial>; Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 106-107.

³⁷ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 101-102.

³⁸ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920-21*, 147-156.

³⁹ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 104.

⁴⁰ John Humphreys et al., "Upward Defiance in Organizations: Management Lessons from the Battle of Blair Mountain" *Journal of Management History*. 19, no. 3 (2013): 305. <https://doi.org/10.1108/jmh-05-2012-0039>.

⁴¹ Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America's Largest Labor Uprising*, 107.

John Locke, who asserted the supremacy of inalienable natural rights and notably the right to rebellion.⁴² In his *Second Treatise of Government*, Locke argues that where a people are subjected to relentless, egregious abuses of power and harm, they are bound to take whatever course of action is necessary to alleviate this suffering and injustice.⁴³ Locke endorses a rebellion under such circumstances where the outcome may be to bring relief to a wronged group and reorient authority to a position of serving the populace, as opposed to oppressing them. He further argues that by pushing their subjects to a point where rebellion becomes necessary, the unjust authority in that case has put themselves in a situation where they are aggressing upon the populace; and thus actions to depose them would be undertaken as a means of collective self-defence.⁴⁴ Labour leader Fred Mooney would highlight the violation of fundamental rights in his testimony to the United States Senate, where he charged that the efforts to stifle unionization were a denial of the right to public assembly, the right to free association, and that these efforts by coal operators and their allies amounted to an attack on the notion of a republican form of government.⁴⁵ Such actions are in violation of the fundamental right in the United States to “the right of the people peaceably to assemble”.⁴⁶ That the aggrieved miners had chosen to take up arms was also well within the revolutionary tradition of the country; they were exercising their right to keep and bear arms in order to protect the foundation of the free society they sought to live in.⁴⁷ Despite allegations later pushed by anti-union voices, the miners for the most part had no intention of fundamentally restructuring the democratic, market-based system. Rather,

⁴² “Creating the United States: Revolution of the Mind”,
<https://www.loc.gov/exhibits/creating-the-united-states/revolution-of-the-mind.html>.

⁴³ John Locke, “Of the Dissolution of Government” in *Second Treatise of Government* (1690), Sect. 223-224.

⁴⁴ Locke, “Of the Dissolution of Government”, Sect. 225-227.

⁴⁵ *West Virginia Coal Fields: Hearings Before the Committee on Education and Labor, United States Senate, 67th Congress, 1st Session, Pursuant to S. Res. 80, Directing the Committee on Education and Labor to Investigate the Recent Acts of Violence in the Coal Fields of West Virginia and Adjacent Territory and the Causes which Led to the Conditions which Now Exist in Said Territory*, 20.

⁴⁶ United States Constitution, amend. 1.

⁴⁷ United States Constitution, amend. 2.

they wanted to maintain the promise of “opportunity, individual freedom, and fairness under the law” for themselves. This explained why they had chosen not to engage Federal troops in combat alongside the fact that many of them had served alongside the troops during the Great War; their fight was with the coal mine operators, corrupt local law enforcement, and the Baldwin-Felts agents responsible for carrying out their repression.⁴⁸

In closing, the Battle of Blair Mountain was the culmination of years of simmering tensions, with occasional flashes of violence occurring in the lead up to the bloodshed unleashed in late 1921. Coal mine operators, keen to avoid the financial costs associated with the industry’s downturn, offloaded the burden onto coal miners and their families. The dictatorial control mining companies and their hired guns such as the Baldwin-Felts Detective Agency exerted over the mining communities of southern West Virginia alongside appalling working and living conditions led to skirmishes between organized labour and mining company interests. This in turn led to masses of armed and determined coal miners to attempt an overthrow of the status quo in West Virginia that posed a detriment to their livelihoods and futures. The result was open civil warfare in the mountainous terrain of southern West Virginia of the likes that has not been seen since on United States soil. This collective action taken by the coal miners was in line with American revolutionary ideals that stress the right to rebel against unfair, tyrannical governance with the use of armed force. Rather than seeking to tear down the foundations that the United States had been built upon, these coal miners fought to ensure that its promises of free and fair governance and inalienable fundamental rights applied to them as well. Left without recourse, they engaged in armed insurrection to ameliorate their circumstances and bring about justice for downtrodden labourers, their families, and their communities.

⁴⁸ Savage, *Thunder in the Mountains: The West Virginia Mine War, 1920–21*, 147-148; Shogan, *The Battle of Blair Mountain: The Story of America’s Largest Labor Uprising*, 109.

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